

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	FULL MOON	NEW MOON
2020	August 3	August 19
2021	August 22	August 8
2022	August 12	August 27
2023	August 1, 31	August 16
2024	August 19	August 4
2025	August 9	August 23
2026	August 28	August 12
2027	August 17	August 2, 31

PLANETS

2020: August 13 Venus is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude -4.3.

2021: August 2 Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.2.

2021: August 9 Jupiter is at opposition, magnitude -2.9.

2022: August 14 Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.3.

2022: August 10 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.5.

2023: August 26 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.6.

2023: August 27 Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.4.

2025: August 19 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.2.

2026: August 2 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.5.

2026: August 15 Venus is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -4.0.

ECLIPSES

2026: August 12 A total eclipse of the Sun is visible from northern Spain, the North Atlantic, Greenland, Iceland, and the Arctic, with a partial eclipse visible in northwest Africa, Europe, and northern North America.

2026: August 27-28 A partial eclipse of the Moon is visible across the Americas, Europe, Africa, the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans, and Antarctica.

AUGUST

The Summer Triangle formed by the bright stars Vega (in Lyra), Deneb (in Cygnus), and Altair (in Aquila) lies on the north-south celestial meridian in the northern sky this month. The cross-shaped figure of Cygnus, the swan, stands out against the background of the Milky Way, which passes overhead in mid-northern latitudes. In the southern sky, the rich Milky Way star fields in Sagittarius and Scorpius, toward the center of the galaxy, remain well placed for observation.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

Blue-white Vega (see p.253), in the constellation Lyra, is the first bright star to appear overhead as the sky darkens on August evenings. Next to Lyra is Cygnus, popularly known as the Northern Cross. The star at the head of Cygnus, Albireo, is a beautifully colored double star, easily divided by the smallest of telescopes. South of Cygnus is Aquila, the Eagle, from where the Milky Way continues, via Scutum, toward Sagittarius and Scorpius in the southwest. Hercules and

Ophiuchus remain well placed in the southwest, and Arcturus, in Boötes, is lower in the west. In the east, the Square of Pegasus leads the stars of fall into view.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

The August skies are stocked with deep-sky objects for northern observers. The Milky Way is divided by a dark dust cloud known as the Cygnus Rift, which extends southwestward from Cygnus into Ophiuchus. South of Cygnus, in the obscure constellation Vulpecula, is the planetary nebula M27, popularly known as the Dumbbell,

the easiest such object to see through binoculars. Another celebrated planetary nebula, the Ring Nebula (see p.257) or M27, in Lyra, can be found with a telescope. The Wild Duck Cluster, or M11, in Scutum is a 6th-magnitude open cluster visible through binoculars.

METEOR SHOWER

The year's top meteor shower, the Perseids, reaches a peak around August 12, although some activity can be seen for a week or so on either side of this date. Perseid meteors are bright: at best, an average of one a minute can be seen streaking away from northern Perseus. Most Perseids are seen after midnight, because Perseus does not rise high before then.

